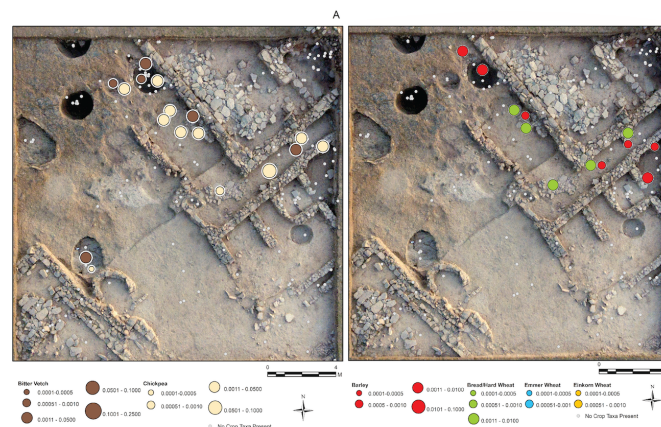
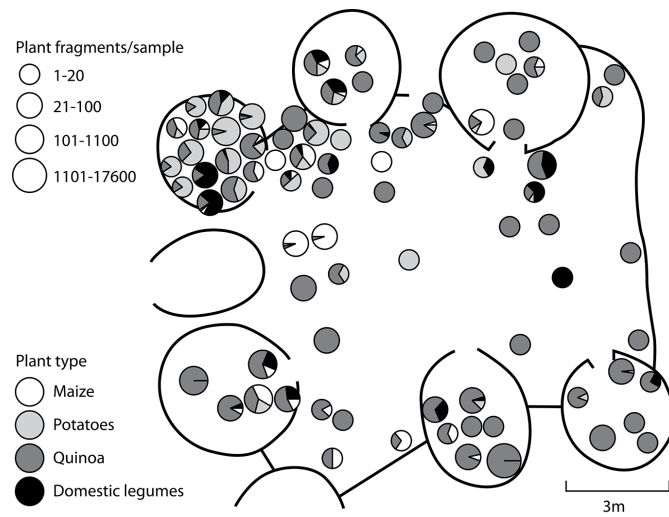


Interpreting Plant Remains

Eventually, paleoethnobotanists produce detailed data sets for each type of botanical remains recovered. For each category of remains (e.g., phytoliths, starch granules), a table that lists all of the plants recovered and the count of the specific types of remains for each plant is usually the first data set produced. This can be further broken down to distinguish specific samples that may represent different areas of the site or types of contexts (e.g., grouping all the hearths together, or comparing floors of different rooms, or comparing midden deposits). Often, these samples are grouped by chronological phase of the site, as well.

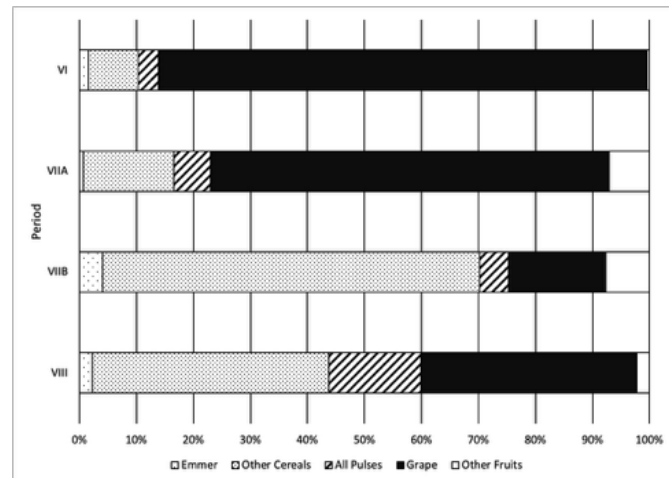
Paleoethnobotanists then use these data to produce interpretive diagrams that show the relative frequency of different types of plants across a site. This method can illuminate changes in plant use over space or time, which then can be interpreted in the context of the preparation, consumption, and disposal of food.





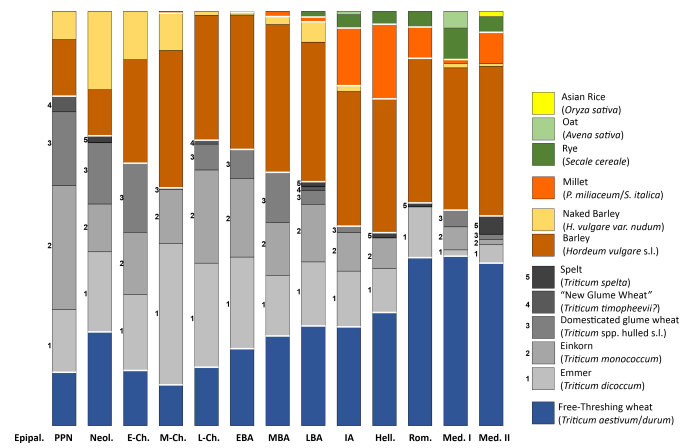
Pie-chart map showing differential use of plants over space within a household compound in the Mantaro Valley of Peru. Basic patterning (i.e., maize processed outside, potatoes primarily in upper-left structure) is visible through this spatial analysis. Image redrawn after original by Christine Hastorf.

Source: Dr. Marston



Chronological analysis of major crop types during four phases of the Hellenistic period at the site of Ashkelon, Israel.

Source: Dr. Marston



Chronological analysis of changes in cereal agriculture over the last 10,000 years from all sites in modern Turkey, summed together.

Source: Dr. Marston

Further interpretation of botanical remains can then proceed in a number of directions. Where did people use specific plants, and how were those plants processed for use? What plants did people grow locally, gather in the wild, or import through trade? How were plants used in medicine and industry, as well as food? Where did people maintain crop fields, and why were those locations chosen? What methods were used to cultivate those plants, and why? These questions and more are asked and answered using paleoethnobotanical remains.